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CHINA AND THE KOREAN PENINSULA

A Chinese View

Hao Yufan

History and geography have combined to make the Korean peninsula vitally important to China's security. This importance lies not only in the fact that the peninsula shares a fairly long border with China's industrial heartland in the northeastern provinces, but it also stems from the convergence—and often the clash—of the interests of the Soviet Union, Japan, and the United States in Korea. For the last century, Korea has served as an object or area of conflict and an invasion corridor for these three powerful states. The Chinese involvement in the Korean War in 1950–53 in support of North Korea after the United States intervened on behalf of South Korea, together with the close ties between the leadership of the Chinese Communist Party and the Korean Workers Party led by Kim Il Sung that dates from the 1930s, have reinforced the importance of Korea in China's policy calculations.

Since the founding of the People's Republic of China (PRC), Beijing's Korean policy has been strongly influenced by its overall security concerns. This policy has basically gone through three periods, with China-North Korean relations as its cornerstone. In the 1950s, China saw the United States as the major threat to its security and it allied itself with the Soviet Union and supported the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK) against the American-backed South Korean regime. From the early 1960s to the 1970s, while the United States remained a security threat, the Sino-Soviet dispute created a new threat that included the danger the DPRK might become an exclusive ally of Moscow, unfriendly to China. Chinese regional policy was therefore twofold: to support the DPRK in the struggle against U.S.-backed South Korea on the one hand,

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and to dissuade Kim Il Sung from taking the Soviet side in the Sino-Soviet rivalry. Throughout the 1970s, China's first priority was to deal with an increasing Soviet threat to its security. For this purpose, China developed a new relationship with the United States and Japan. At the same time, Beijing carefully maintained its relations with the DPRK, though not without difficulties.[1]

Since the beginning of the 1980s, the security environment of the Northeast Asian region surrounding the Korean peninsula has been undergoing significant change and has become fluid. All the major powers still seem to support the common, minimum objective of maintaining the stability of the region. There remain, however, many uncertainties involving this sensitive and heavily armed area. The fluid and dynamic situation poses a serious challenge to China's regional objectives and has attracted more and more attention from Beijing's foreign policy makers. What are the important recent changes in and around the Korean peninsula? What will be China's Korean policy in the remainder of the 1980s? This essay attempts to answer these questions by examining two major interrelated factors that play a pivotal role in shaping China's Korean policy: (1) the changing regional situation; and (2) China's fundamental policy objectives in the area. The essay will analyze trends that seem to be of particular significance for Chinese interests, and will discuss how the changing strategic environment has affected and will continue to affect Beijing's pursuit of its regional interests.

Trends In and Around the Korean Peninsula

Chinese policy toward Korea is largely influenced by the security environment in and around the peninsula. The situation in the area could be regarded as a kind of balance of power or equilibrium in which the six parties constantly interact and adjust their relationships, each trying not only to maintain and improve its position but also to prevent a dangerous new imbalance from emerging.

Since the 1980s began, challenges to the regional equilibrium have been looming on the horizon. Four trends seem particularly significant for the evolution of the security environment in general, and for China's regional policy in particular: 1) the rapid Soviet military buildup in the region; 2) the improvement of Soviet-North Korean relations; 3) the unstable

1. For a useful assessment of recent Sino-North Korean relations, see Chae-jin Lee, "China's Policy Towards North Korea: Changing Relations in the 1980s," in Robert Scalapino and Hongkoo Lee, eds., *North Korea in a Regional and Global Context* (Berkeley: Institute of East Asian Studies, University of California, 1986), pp. 190–240.

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political situation within the peninsula; and 4) the growth of the economic and military power of South Korea.

The Soviet Military Buildup

The first and most significant trend that has challenged the balanced situation is the rapid increase in Soviet military capabilities. The Soviets believe that the existing balance of power in this region has been more or less unfavorable to them since the 1970s, and they are determined to improve their current position by increasing their own influence and power there.

The Soviet Union's Far East policy has had three main ingredients since the 1970s: 1) to challenge the United States in East Asia; 2) to contain China in an effort to keep China weak; and 3) to discourage Japan from becoming a strong military power, and to prevent any Sino-U.S.-Japanese entente against the USSR. This policy was not very successful in the 1970s.[2] China moved into a de facto, if very loose, cooperation with the United States and Japan. Subsequently, it has begun a modernization program which, by the year 2000, could significantly increase its power. America's relations with East Asia have never been better. It has an extensive alliance system in East Asia, and has for the first time in this century maintained good relations with both China and Japan.

Thus, the Soviets believed that a rapid buildup of their military and arms assistance capability would be a major means to change their unfavorable status. Actually, Moscow started its buildup in the late 1960s, and it has basically undergone two stages: the first, from the late 1960s to the early 1970s, emphasized the rapid buildup of ground forces deployed primarily against China. The second stage involved the deployment of a new generation of intermediate-range nuclear weapons, the major expansion and qualitative improvement of its Pacific Fleet, and the development and extension of Soviet bases in the territories north of Japan. Its objective began to include a military capability to counter U.S. air and naval deployment in the Pacific and to interdict the sea and air lines of communication linking the United States with the region in order to neutralize the potential for U.S.-China-Japan cooperation.

As a result, the USSR now has a formidable array of military forces in Northeast Asia. These include some 35–40% of its ICBM force and ballistic missile submarines (SLBM), 25% of its ground forces and fighter aircraft, and more than 30% of its strategic bombers and navy forces.[3]

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2. Donald S. Zagoria, "The Strategic Environment in East Asia," in Donald S. Zagoria, ed., *Soviet Policy in East Asia* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1982), pp. 1-27.

3. Paul Dibb, "Soviet Capabilities, Interests and Strategies in East Asia in the 1980s," *Survival*, July-August, 1982, p. 155.

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Moreover, these forces now have been equipped with some of the most modern weapons in the Soviet inventory, including a Kiev-class aircraft carrier displacing 40,000 tons (the *Minsk*), an amphibious assault ship (the *Ivan Rogov*), Delta-class SSNBs, MiG-25 "Foxbat" fighters, MiG-27 "Floggers", Tu-22M "Backfire" bombers, Tu-95s ("Bear/E"), and SS-20 IRBMs.[4] This buildup in East Asia has taken the Soviet Union a considerable way along the road toward its goal of altering the balance in its favor. In the process, it has begun to change the basic structure of power in the region.[5]

Although Soviet leaders for the last decade have behaved as if they assign the Korean peninsula a low priority in their overall East Asian policy, this attitude has undergone a gradual change recently.[6] The Sea of Okhotsk has become much more important to the USSR as a bastion for SSBNs whose long-range missiles have been targeted on the U.S. since the early 1980s. Over the same period, the Soviets have been steadily augmenting the role of Northeast Asia as a platform and staging area for the wartime deployment southward, to the Cam Ranh Bay base in Vietnam and the Indian Ocean.

Given the growing geostrategic importance of Northeast Asia to Moscow, and the fundamental and long-term nature of its competition with the United States and China, the Soviets are not likely to change this current policy orientation. A strong military presence and capability in the region have simply become too important for Moscow to neglect. Therefore, the Soviet buildup in the region is likely to remain a constant feature of the strategic environment through the 1980s. Although the magnitude and speed of the buildup may vary, it seems unlikely that the Soviets will halt, let alone reverse, the process.

China's interests certainly are not served by this Soviet buildup in Northeast Asia. First of all, the qualitative and quantitative military buildup increases the threat to China's security. Second, it could threaten the regional power equilibrium and affect the quadrilateral relationship among the U.S., Japan, China, and the USSR, and the balance of forces between North and South Korea. Third, it might also increase the possibility of major Japanese rearmament efforts, which also would be undesir-

4. See Institute of International Strategic Studies (IISS), *Military Balance 1985–1986*, (London: IISS, 1986).

5. Norman D. Levin, *Strategic Environment in East Asia and US-Korea Security Relations in the 1980s*, Rand Notes, March 1983, p. 3.

6. Harry Gelman and Norman D. Levin, *The Future of Soviet-North Korean Relations*, Rand Corporation Report, October 1984.

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able for China's interests. This trend has been of increasing concern to Chinese leaders in the 1980s.

The Improvement of Soviet-DPRK Relations

Related to the rise of Soviet expansion in East Asia is a trend toward improvement of relations between the USSR and the DPRK.[7] Over the years this relationship has fluctuated widely: from extremely close in the early 1950s, to an almost total break in the early 1960s, with variations between the two extremes from the mid-1960s to the early 1980s. These fluctuations indicate some divergence of interests and difficulties in managing differences in their bilateral relations, as well as the mutual distrust imbedded therein. However, strategic needs, as perceived by both sides, have held the two countries together.

The USSR's interests in North Korea are primarily security concerns defined in terms of the Soviet global and regional perspective. The strengthened U.S.-Japan and U.S.-South Korean security alliances and the possibility of U.S.-Japan-China cooperation directed against the USSR have augmented the strategic importance of North Korea to the Soviets. Its economic interests there are marginal, but its political interests demand that Pyongyang not side with China in the Sino-Soviet rivalry. For North Korea, the Soviet Union is the principal source of economic and military aid and the guarantor, though not a totally reliable one, of its security in the face of the external threat. Pyongyang hopes, while maintaining its independence, that Moscow will lend full support in its unification and political struggle against the South.

Throughout the 1970s, Pyongyang tilted markedly to Beijing rather than Moscow. It published China's attacks on the USSR, criticized Cuba, condemned Vietnam, and denounced "dominationism," which was clearly aimed at the Soviet Union. At the same time, Kim Il Sung has always held open the possibility of improving relations with Moscow, and has wanted to demonstrate North Korea's independence of Beijing. In the context of Beijing-Pyongyang strains in 1979-80, Kim Il Sung began to make cautious overtures to the Soviets, signalling a desire for improved bilateral relations, but the Soviets showed little response until after Brezhnev's death in late 1982. The Korean Airlines incident and the Rangoon bombing in 1983 provided opportunities for the two to move closer together. When a Soviet fighter plane shot down the KAL airliner, Pyongyang, after

7. For useful assessments of Soviet-North Korean relations, see Young C. Kim, "Pyongyang, Moscow, and Peking," *Problems of Communism,* Nov.-Dec. 1978; Harry Gelman and Norman D. Levin, *Future of Soviet-North Korean Relations*; Ralph Clough, "The Soviet Union and the Two Koreas," in D. Zagoria, ed., *Soviet Policy in East Asia.*

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three weeks of silence, endorsed the Moscow explanation of the incident, blaming the United States. Shortly thereafter the Rangoon bombing occurred, and the Soviets published Pyongyang's defense of its position and ignored the official Burmese account.[8]

North Korean-Soviet relations have seen a steady and substantial improvement since Kim Il Sung's official visit to the USSR in May 1984. Although there were no immediately visible benefits, Pyongyang began to change its attitude toward the Soviet Union. One remarkable change was Pyongyang's willingness to express gratitude to the Soviets for the defeat of Japan and liberation of Korea. For years, the Soviets had felt aggrieved because the North Koreans had attributed the liberation of Korea exclusively to the efforts of the Korean People's Revolutionary Army led by Kim Il Sung. On Liberation Day in 1984, Kim, for the first time in many years, praised the "liberating role played by the Soviet Union."[9] Through this expression of gratitude, Pyongyang attempted to remove an irritating and emotional obstacle in its relations with Moscow.

In November 1984, Soviet Deputy Foreign Minister Mikhail Kapitsa made a 13-day visit to Pyongyang to negotiate a new border treaty, which was signed in Moscow in April 1985. This treaty apparently gave both countries better access to each other's territory, economically and militarily. As a result, the Soviets agreed to supply North Korea with advanced MiG-23 fighter aircraft.[10] Recent Soviet aircraft overflights across the narrow neck of North Korea's east-west corridor along the DMZ, may also be a result of the border treaty. Soviet First Deputy Premier Geydar Aliyev went to Pyongyang in August 1985 to attend the celebration of the 40th Anniversary of Korea's Liberation. He was accompanied by First Deputy Minister of Defense Marshal V. Petrov, who reportedly offered SAM-3 missiles to North Korea. It is worth noting that Pyongyang did not invite China to attend the ceremony, a clear indication of North Korea's tilt toward the Soviets. To underscore the warming of Soviet-North Korean relations and military cooperation, three Soviet warships, headed by the flagship *Tallin* with the first deputy commander of the Soviet Pacific Fleet aboard, visited Wonsan, the first Soviet navy port visit to North Korea.[11]

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8. China published the Burmese accounts side by side with the North Koreans' defense; see *Renmin Ribao*, August 1983.

9. FBIS, *Daily Report, Asia & Pacific*, August 16, 1984, p. C–1.

10. See IISS report, May 3, 1985, as cited by *Korea Herald*, May 5, 1985.

11. Richard Nations, "Love Boat to Wonsan," *Far Eastern Economic Review* (hereafter *FEER*), August 29, 1985, p. 22.

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Why did Moscow-Pyongyang relations improve so dramatically in the 1984–85 period? For Pyongyang, trends in Chinese domestic and foreign policy must have worried the North Koreans. However, more important than the China factor were Pyongyang's military and economic needs. With the improvement of South Korean-U.S. relations and the scheduled receipt of F-16s by Seoul in 1986, Pyongyang must have felt more keenly than ever the need for more military and economic support from Moscow.

On the Soviet side, the most important reason for closer relations with North Korea has been Moscow's concern over what it has regarded as an emerging U.S.-China-Japan cooperative relationship. The beginning of military cooperation between Washington and Beijing, though so far limited, has alarmed the Soviets[12] who fear the emergence of a less favorable position for them in the Northeast Asian balance. The second reason is Soviet concern about being excluded from diplomacy relating to the Korean peninsula. Kim Il Sung asked the Chinese rather than the Soviets to pass the tripartite talks proposal to the United States in 1983, and Washington's counter-proposal for four-party talks included China but not the USSR. Improving relations between Pyongyang and Moscow may be considered necessary to prevent Moscow's exclusion from decision making on the Korean peninsula.

This trend seems likely to continue, and therefore demands special attention.[13] The reported Soviet access to North Korean airspace allows reconnaissance flights against China, threatening not only the Manchurian industrial sector but also the Bohai Gulf and the Yellow Sea shipping lanes and the Northern Fleet headquarters at Qingdao. The level of concessions and bargaining required of the Soviets to gain such a foothold on the peninsula underscores the rising importance of Korea in the eyes of the Kremlin leadership. It further indicates to China the Soviet desire to obtain other major assets from Pyongyang by offering supplies of high-tech weaponry which China cannot provide.

Political Developments in the Peninsula

Political developments in both Seoul and Pyongyang introduce an element of unpredictability into current policies and prospects for regional stability. In North Korea, the most noticeable uncertainty is that posed by leadership succession. Kim Il Sung has made clear his intention of designating

12. For China-U.S. military relations, see Edward Ross, "US-China Military Relations," A Presentation to the Heritage Foundation, January 1986; also Jonathan Pollack, *The Lesson of Coalition Politics: Sino-American Security Relations*, Rand Corporation Report, Fall 1984.

13. At the invitation of Gorbachev, Kim Il Sung arrived in Moscow on October 22, 1986. See *Renmin Ribao*, October 23, 1986.

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Kim Chong-il, his eldest son, as his successor. Kim Chong-il has attained the highest position in the party second only to that of his father, and several people closely identified with him have begun to appear in high positions.

Political succession is not an event but a process, and Pyongyang began this process in 1973. By all accounts it is well advanced and, at least in contrast to that of China in the Maoist period, appears relatively smooth and harmonious. A combination of circumstances—the absence of any serious rivals for power, Kim Il Sung's good health that has given him time to prepare for the succession, the isolation of North Korea, and the approval of Beijing and Moscow—has enhanced the probability that it may be effectively accomplished even before Kim leaves the scene.[14]

Nevertheless, the succession process in the DPRK is still underway and may well continue for many years. The key question is how much time will Kim Chong-il need to consolidate his position and establish his own leadership credentials. Kim Il Sung enjoys the status he does today not only because of his accomplishments but also because of his success in defeating challenges both inside and outside North Korea. Whether Chong-il is capable of strengthening his own power beyond challenge is still uncertain.

There are at least three possibilities for the power transition, with three different consequences for regional stability. The most likely one is the success of the process. Should Kim Chong-il succeed, it would probably mean a continuation of Kim Il Sung's policies. The idea of *chuch'e*, or independence in foreign policy, would remain. However, Chong-il would likely be called upon to decide numerous important issues regarding North Korea's economic development strategy, unification, and North-South relations. When there are conflicting opinions, it seems that Chong-il would have to make certain modifications in his father's revolutionary goals in order to insure the smooth functioning of North Korea's political, economic, and military systems. But it seems highly unlikely that Kim Chong-il would substantially change the DPRK's current policies.

The second possibility is that the post-Kim Il Sung leadership will be a coalition government. After Kim's death, Kim Chong-il might meet opposition from more senior figures in the party and army. A coalition might be formed after substantial compromises from both sides. In this situation,

14. See Chong-sik Lee, "The Evolution of the Korean Workers' Party and the Rise of Kim Chong il," in Robert A. Scalapino and Jun-yop Kim, eds., *North Korea Today: Strategic and Domestic Issues* (Berkeley: Institute of East Asian Studies, University of California, 1983); also Byung Chul Koh, "Political Succession in North Korea," *Korea & World Affairs*, 8:3, Fall 1984.

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the new leaders in Pyongyang might substantially modify Kim's revolutionary tradition, especially the identification of self-reliance as a fundamental objective, and the unification strategy. There are two possibilities in these circumstances in terms of Pyongyang's foreign relations: first, that Pyongyang's new leadership might still keep on the old track in relations with Beijing, as defined by Kim Il Sung, and second, the new leadership might adopt a pro-Moscow stance and distance itself from Beijing for economic and military reasons.

The least likely outcome is for a power struggle to take place, with the military taking over when Kim Il Sung is gone. In this situation, the junior Kim or one of his rivals for power might seek to win the succession struggle by involving Moscow or Beijing in it. The Russians seem to be positioning themselves to exploit internal divisions within the North Korean leadership.[15] Such a new leadership in Pyongyang might be tempted to pursue an adventurist policy against the South as a means of strengthening its own claims, and might make substantial concessions to Moscow in exchange for military and economic aid.

An important trend has been the growth of political instability in South Korea, rooted in the desire of the South Korean people to end the excessive personalization of politics in the South and their desire to institutionalize political democracy. Since the early 1960s, South Korean politics have been characterized by military dictatorship. Park Chung Hee, a general, rose to power with a coup and ruled increasingly as a dictator for nearly two decades. In 1979 he was assassinated, and within a few months a young military officer, Chun Doo-hwan, seized power in another coup. The people's discontent increased as a result of the bloodletting in a major incident in Kwangju. One-man rule has continued, but inside the society profound forces have been moving in the direction of ending the excessive personalization of political power.

In the 1985 legislative election, the just-formed opposition New Korea Democratic Party won nearly a third of the vote, while support for the ruling Democratic Justice Party (DJP) declined considerably. Since March 1986, the political opposition has mounted a nationwide campaign urging a constitutional provision for direct presidential elections. Thousands of people have demonstrated in the streets, and anti-American slogans have appeared frequently. This time, a rising and well-educated middle class has begun to join the opposition forces, demanding political participation. It seems that the situation could lead to an end of the military rule that has persisted over the past 25 years.[16] Bowing to strong

15. See Gelman and Levin, *The Future of Soviet-North Korean Relations.*
16. Washington Post, May 5, 1986, p. A19.

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pressure from the opposition, Chun made a concession in late 1986 by asserting that he would not stand in the way of any early constitutional amendment if the parliament agreed to it.[17] But his subsequent actions followed by some of the largest street demonstrations South Korea has ever seen have left the current situation extremely fluid and speculation risky.

The situation in South Korea will probably remain unstable during the years immediately ahead, and the possible consequences for the strategic environment demand attention. One is that Seoul might exaggerate the threat from the North, escalate the arms race, and even take some provocative action to divert public attention from domestic problems. The other possibility is that North Korea might seek to exploit this uncertain political situation and try to achieve unification by force. To sum up, the remainder of the 1980s will be a critical period for the two Korean states. Both face unprecedented leadership successions and the political uncertainties that these create.

Growth of the Economic and Military Power of South Korea

The fourth trend concerns the growth of South Korea's economic and military power. Its economic development has been impressive in the postwar period, while the growth rate of the North Korean economy, though rapid in the first two decades after the end of the Korean War, has slowed down since the 1970s due to rigidity in structure and strategy, outmoded technology, and the diversion of resources to the military in response to perceived external threats. South Korea now enjoys more advanced economic and industrial capability than the North. In 1984, the South Korean gross domestic product (GDP) was US$83.2 billion, while that of the North was estimated at US$39.9 billion.[18] South Korean technology is also believed to be superior to that of the North. Unless Pyongyang changes its development strategy, the present gap will continue to grow.

When the North and South are compared militarily, North Korea is believed to have a considerable quantitative superiority in military equipment as a result of an intensive defense buildup during the 1960s and 1970s. In 1985, North Korea maintained a large military force of 838,000 soldiers, 800 aircraft, and 502 vessels, while the South Korean military consisted of 620,000 soldiers, 440 aircraft, and 110 vessels.[19] However,

17. Christian Science Monitor, May 2, 1986, p. 13.
18. IISS, *Military Balance 1985–1986.*
19. Ibid., pp. 126–27.

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upon close inspection, North Korea's numerical advantage turns out to be misleading: almost 40% of its aircraft consist of outmoded MiG-15s and MiG-17s; only its MiG-21s are considered roughly equal to the South's F-5s. Although the delivery of 40 MiG-23s by the Soviets may upgrade Pyongyang's air power, South Korea still seems to enjoy an edge. In terms of naval vessels, Pyongyang's advantage is also dubious: 62% of its vessels are fast-attack craft equipped with guns or torpedoes while 19% are landing craft and 11% are coastal patrol craft.[20]

South Korea has been expanding and modernizing its military forces since the middle of the 1970s (beginning twelve years later than the North) under its Force Improvement Plan (FIP) I (1976–82) and II (1982–87). Its military budget has been increased substantially, close to 6% of its GNP. Though this percentage is less than that of the North, its US$4.402 billion military budget is bigger than the US$4.19 billion of the North. After the successful completion of FIP I and II, the South will eventually surpass the North and remain ahead throughout the 1980s. This could trigger an escalation in the arms race that would further increase the possibility for destabilization in the peninsula.

The growing gap in economic power between the North and South, coupled with the growth of South Korean military power, suggests that Pyongyang's leadership is confronted with some difficult choices: 1) doing nothing and watching South Korea "win the race" economically while acquiring the base for military superiority; 2) changing its approach by opening its economy to the West as China has done, soliciting capital and technology; 3) leaning further toward the Soviets in order to obtain more capital and technology from them, meshing its economy into COMECON, and partially giving up its independence; and 4) taking direct or indirect military action, as many Western observers fear, to try to undermine or set back South Korea's economic progress. The fourth is almost impossible due to the lack of enough military strength in the North and the U.S. military presence in the peninsula. Recently there have been some indications that North Korea intends to choose the second option. A new joint venture law enacted in North Korea in September 1984, together with "the trade development resolution" adopted by the Seventh Supreme People's Assembly in January 1984, are expressions of North Korea's altered economic development strategy.[21] However, both past patterns and recent trends suggest that the third alternative demands careful attention by the Chinese leadership.

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20. Ibid., p. 127.

21. See Byung Chul Koh, "China and the Korean Peninsula," in *Korea & World Affairs*, Summer 1985, pp. 254–79.

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China's Current Objectives and Possible Approaches

The trends described above are the most significant factors affecting the security environment in Northeast Asia as far as regional stability is concerned. These trends have two basic features: the rising Soviet power and influence and the increase in destabilizing factors. In the long run, these are moving in a direction not congenial to Chinese interests. What are China's regional objectives, and how will China respond in the context of these trends in the remainder of the 1980s? China's policy toward the Korean peninsula is largely a function of its overall foreign policy concerns, which at present are based on the following premises:

(1) The Soviet Union is the main threat to China's security. From the Chinese perspective, the center of Moscow's Asian policy is to strategically encircle and weaken China. The steady growth of Soviet ground, air, naval, and strategic forces deployed in East Asia, together with Soviet success in expanding its influence in Indochina and Afghanistan, pose a major challenge to the PRC's security interests.

(2) Despite this major threat from the Soviet Union, military conflict with the Soviets is unlikely in the near future. Therefore, China does not need to increase its military buildup in any dramatic way at present. Meanwhile, a moderate reduction of tensions between Beijing and Moscow is in China's interests.[22]

(3) China needs a fairly long period of peace in order to modernize its economy, upgrade its industrial and defense capacity, and become strong enough in the long run to defend itself in the face of external threats. For this purpose, Beijing needs to maintain political stability and unity at home and a peaceful external environment.

(4) The United States is not a threat to China's security at present. On the contrary, it is a potential strategic partner in the face of the threat from the Soviet Union. Therefore, to maintain good relations with the United States is very important to China's interests.

(5) However, China does not want to be involved in the superpowers' global competition, in which China's relatively weak military position makes its security uncertain. Thus, it is not in China's interest to enter into an exclusive alliance with either the United States or the Soviet Union.[23]

(6) The principal sources of capital and technology needed to modernize China are Japan, the United States, and West Europe.

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22. See "Vice Premier Li Peng on Foreign Relations and Domestic Policy," in *Liaowang* (Weekly Outlook), vol. II, March 17, 1986, pp. 3–4.

23. See Peng Di's article, "Changes in Chinese Foreign Policy?," in *Liaowang*, vol. II, March 17, 1986, pp. 3–4.

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(7) To have a good and healthy relationship, especially economic cooperation, with Japan is very important. At the same time, China would not like to see the Japanese rearm themselves rapidly. A militarily strong Japan is not in China's interests.[24]

These foreign policy calculations require China to pursue an independent and peaceful foreign policy. This policy in turn requires its regional policy toward the Korean peninsula to be aimed at three basic objectives: First, to maintain regional stability and the existing balance. Any developments in and around the Korean peninsula that will lead to instability will be regarded as adverse to Chinese interests. Considering the peninsula as an area of tension and military buildup, China hopes that tensions will be relaxed and peaceful reunification gradually realized. Second, given the strategic importance of, and the unique set of cultural, historical, geographical and political ties with North Korea, maintaining good relations with Pyongyang is crucial. Third, it is in China's interest that the bilateral relationship between the DPRK and China be maintained in a way that will not adversely affect Beijing's relations with Washington and Tokyo.

China's reasons for desiring stability in Korea are obvious. A military conflict would impose upon the Chinese an extremely serious dilemma that Beijing is neither willing nor ready to face. Bound by explicit treaty obligations to North Korea and repeated security commitments, and influenced by the Soviet factor, China might find it extremely difficult to refuse to assist the DPRK if a conflict were to occur. This would inevitably damage China's cooperative ties with the United States and Japan and could compromise China's economic modernization program. If the Soviet Union were to enter such an open conflict and the Soviet-DPRK defense treaty were invoked, this would further complicate and worsen China's position. Soviet influence in North Korea would increase substantially as only the Soviets could supply sophisticated weapons for a military confrontation with a U.S.-backed South Korea. Therefore, the primary objective of China's regional policy is to maintain stability and reduce tension in the peninsula.

Beijing's overriding security interests in Korea cannot be protected without a good relationship with Pyongyang. Even if regional stability is maintained, if North Korea—like Vietnam—allies itself with the Soviets, the consequences might be as adverse to China's interest as instability in Korea. North Korea is the critical link for Moscow to complete its chain of encirclement around China. "A Second Vietnam" in the Korean penin-

24. In addition to the strong response to the Japanese textbook issue, Chinese media have been reporting more general "unfavorable" trends in Japan. For a recent commentary, see Li Nan's article, "What Does the Fujio Issue Tell Us," in *Liaowang*, September 22, 1986, p. 27.

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sula would give the Kremlin a crucial "knife" pointing at the heartland of China's industry and resources. Politically, Pyongyang's importance has loomed large within the perspective of China's current status in international Communist affairs. It is important to Chinese prestige and influence that Kim Il Sung refuse to support the Moscow-sponsored campaign against Beijing and that he cooperate with China in the Third World, especially in the context of the nonaligned movement.

Among China's objectives, the most difficult one is to maintain its relations with North Korea in such a way that Sino-American relations will not be strictly circumscribed. No matter how warm its relations with China, Pyongyang's leadership has always cast a wary eye on Beijing's dealings with Washington, and it always has the Soviet card in its hands. China's political balancing act, therefore, has remained a very delicate one—on the one hand, to persuade the DPRK, that closer Sino-American relations will benefit North Korean interests and that China will do nothing to compromise those interests, and on the other hand, to refuse to play any direct role, as the U.S. has hoped it would, to defuse tension. But this task has proved to be extremely difficult due to the fact that the interests of Beijing and Pyongyang have not always converged, especially on security issues. Although Beijing's leadership considers consultation between the two capitals very important before any major policy shift toward the United States and Japan, the cost nevertheless remains high. Recent trends have demonstrated that Beijing wishes to seek more room for maneuver. China is likely to continue its efforts to achieve a balance between supporting its long-time ally in the North, and maintaining its good relations with Washington and Tokyo.

In pursuing its regional objectives, China is trying to develop an international policy that counters manipulation by either superpower. Since 1982, the PRC has repeatedly declared that it "will never attach itself to any other state or bloc of states".[25] The PRC leadership will continue this effort so long as its current security perceptions remain unchanged.

Although recent trends indicate some possibility for Beijing to ease tensions with Moscow and distance itself from Washington, there appear to be strict limits on how far Beijing is prepared to go in this respect. Beijing's posture toward the Soviet Union, and therefore the United States, is influenced by the Kremlin's stance toward China. Moscow has not reduced its military pressure on China, nor has it met Beijing's three conditions for further improvement in bilateral relations, namely, the withdrawal of troops along the Sino-Soviet and Sino-Mongolian borders,

25. "Foreign Minister Wu Xueqian on Foreign Policy and the International Situation," *Liaowang*, vol. 49, December 9, 1985, pp. 11–13.

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the end to Soviet support for the Vietnamese occupation of Cambodia, and the withdrawal of Soviet troops from Afghanistan. Although Gorbachev has recently indicated that the Soviet Union is considering partial withdrawal of its troops from Mongolia and Afghanistan, there has been no sign of any fundamental shift in Moscow's perceived desire to encircle China.[26]

In the remainder of the 1980s, there will be continuing negotiations between China and the USSR and perhaps a continuing easing of Sino-Soviet hostility. Yet Moscow will continue to be China's primary adversary even if Beijing asserts that the immediacy of the Soviet threat has diminished somewhat in recent years. The United States no longer poses such a threat. And Sino-American relations will still be cooperative, if with areas of friction and disagreement such as the issues of Taiwan, trade, and technology transfer. The current pattern in which China is closer to the U.S. than the USSR is likely to continue.[27]

Beijing's basic interests in the Korean peninsula are likely to mesh well, in a basic sense, with those of Washington during the remainder of the 1980s. Both countries desire regional stability and have no interest in allowing tensions to escalate or radical change to occur in the status quo on the peninsula. However, Beijing and Washington differ on how to achieve stability. Having rejected the Carter administration's policy on the withdrawal of ground troops from South Korea, the Reagan administration now stresses the importance of close U.S.-South Korean political and military cooperation for the region's stability, and seeks to strengthen the U.S. presence in the peninsula.[28] Such attempts serve no good purpose for Beijing's leaders. It makes North Korea take a continuous hostile stance toward the United States and keeps Beijing continuously in a very difficult position in dealing with both.

China-DPRK relations have been and will continue to be the cornerstone of Beijing's regional policy. Although Beijing's relations with the DPRK suffered some strains toward the end of the 1970s due to different perceptions of the security threat and certain domestic policies, these have gradually recovered as the result of the strenuous efforts made by Beijing

26. See Gorbachev's Vladivostok speech in *Washington Post*, July 28, 1986.

27. Beijing recently rejected a secret Soviet invitation to the Chinese premier to visit Moscow. This indicates the unchanged perception of a Soviet threat to China and the limitation of Sino-Soviet relations. See Jim Hoagland, "Long March of Small Steps," *Washington Post*, October 3, 1986, p. A2.

28. See Paul D. Wolfowitz, "Recent Security Developments in Korea," U.S. Department of State, *Current Policy*, no. 731, August 12, 1985.

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subsequently.[29] During the 1980s, Beijing has conducted its relationship with North Korea reasonably well and has kept differences and policy frictions at a manageable level. To maintain a cooperative relationship with North Korea, Beijing will continue its political, diplomatic, and military support and economic aid to Pyongyang in the years ahead. There is no fundamental conflict of interests between China and the DPRK. Like Beijing, Pyongyang's compelling interest at present is to reduce regional tensions and maintain stability for its economic development and peaceful reunification schemes. China has taken every opportunity to assure the United States and Japan that Kim Il Sung has neither the intention nor the capability to invade the South and that the North Koreans are genuinely interested in easing tension in the peninsula. At the same time, Beijing's leadership has tried to persuade Pyongyang that another Korean war would be a disaster for North Korea.

China will continue to encourage Pyongyang's independent foreign policy and its efforts to open its economy to the West, as China has done. Deng Xiaoping took Kim Il Sung to look at the celebrated Sichuan model of enterprise autonomy in 1982 to help Kim understand China's modernization policy and the economic reform. The Chinese leadership sees similar moves by the DPRK as necessary steps to reduce Pyongyang's dependence on Moscow and to reduce tension in the peninsula. Beijing favorably noted the DPRK's recent plan to expand North Korea's economic relations with capitalist countries, increase its annual exports in 1989 by 4.2 times over those of 1980, and to set up special export bases.[30] Even though Pyongyang is reluctant to give up its strategy of self-reliance in its development, Beijing's leaders seem confident that they can influence North Korea's future economic orientation if China's own Four Modernizations program proves to be successful.

Beijing will continue to support North Korea's call for the withdrawal of U.S. troops from the peninsula and the ending of U.S.-ROK joint military exercises. Many area specialists in the West seem to believe that China favors the presence of some U.S. military strength in South Korea as a necessary condition to preserve the military balance and stability and to counterbalance Soviet military power in the region.[31] This view is fun-

29. Domestically, Beijing began to downgrade the role of the late Chairman Mao and to attack the cult of personality, which could not have pleased Kim Il Sung, the object of a cult in North Korea. In foreign affairs, China greatly improved its relations with the DPRK's chief adversaries, the United States and Japan.

30. See *Renmin Ribao*, January 28, 1984.

31. Some even argue that Beijing welcomes an American presence to counter both the Soviets and the Japanese. See William R. Heaton, "America and China: The Coming Dec-

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damentally misleading. Although China sees the U.S. military presence on the Korean peninsula as posing no threat to China's security at present, and perhaps having some merit in maintaining the regional power balance and preventing the South from attacking the North, it is still, in the eyes of Beijing's leadership, a main cause of regional tension.[32]

First, the U.S. military presence has made North Korea nervous and insecure, since Pyongyang continues to regard U.S. "imperialists" and Japanese "militarists" as its mortal enemies who not only present the main obstacle to unification hopes but also pose a serious threat to North Korea's security. The sense of insecurity in Pyongyang has caused the diversion of much of its limited resources to defense-oriented production. This in turn has escalated the arms race between the North and the South, and further reinforced U.S. willingness to maintain and even increase its military power there. This vicious circle is the main destabilizing force in the region and makes the situation explosive and dangerous.

Second, should the North come to perceive South Korea as militarily superior, it could further turn to Moscow as the only available source for the assistance required to defend itself. The fact that South Korea should be able to attain this position, with enthusiastic help from America, by the early 1990s if present trends continue, makes a Pyongyang tilt toward Moscow likely.

Third, the U.S. military presence has motivated the increasing Soviet military buildup in the region as a counter to U.S. power, and this increases the possibility that the superpowers might draw the Korean problem more directly into the global competition. If that happens, it would not only raise the already high level of militarization of the peninsula, but also make far more difficult any negotiations by the two Korean states to ease the military confrontation between them.

The PRC will continue to regard inter-Korean contact as a major means to increase regional stability and solve the Korean problem. Although the talks begun in 1984 were suspended in early 1986 and have not yet resumed, the two sides in June 1986 did test the possibility of cohosting the 1988 Olympic Games.[33] The inter-Korean talks appear to have at least three beneficial implications for China's interests. First, they should serve to reduce tension in the region and thus the possibility of military conflict. Second, they should enable the Chinese to more openly explore unofficial

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ade," in William Buckingham, Jr., ed., *Defense Planning for the 1990s* (Washington, D.C.: National Defense University, 1984), pp. 221–38.

32. See *Guangming Ribao*, October 6, 1986, p. 1; also Tao Bin Wei, "Observation on the Korean Situation," *Beijing Review*, no. 38, September 23, 1985, pp. 16–18.

33. See *Washington Post*, June 10, 1986.

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relations with South Korea. Hu Yaobang asserted that future China-South Korea direct economic ties would be "dependent on how things develop between the North and the South."[34] Third, Beijing should be able to use North Korea's proposal of a confederation arrangement with South Korea to link its own calls for a "one country, two systems" approach to reunification with Taiwan. In February 1985, Deng Xiaoping claimed that the PRC and DPRK shared the same approach to their national reunification.[35]

Since the beginning of the 1980s, Beijing's leadership has been testing the possibility of gaining some maneuvering room in its relations with North Korea. It has shifted from a position that would not countenance any ties at all with Seoul to an increasingly active, nongovernmental relationship. The combination of Beijing's pragmatic open-door economic policy and its efforts to separate politics and economics in its foreign policy, has led to a rapid growth in indirect trade between China and South Korea through Hong Kong. The total value of this indirect trade was estimated to be about US$20 million in 1979, and it increased, in spite of North Korean discontent, to almost US$1 billion in 1985.[36]

Besides indirect trade relations, the airplane hijacking incident of 1983 and the torpedo boat incident of 1985 provided occasions for Beijing to directly contact an unrecognized regime. Chinese sportsmen also have had some contacts with their South Korean counterparts in international games. At the 10th Asian Games in Seoul in 1986, China sent a team of 389 athletes even though North Korea boycotted the games.[37] Beijing has been sensitive to Pyongyang's displeasure with Chinese contacts with Seoul, and has made it clear that China will not contact Seoul officially.[38] Unofficial contacts with South Korea will continue, although it will still be limited in the years ahead due to the importance of the China-DPRK relationship. Wherever there is a policy difference between Beijing and Pyong-

34. This was first revealed by *Nihon Keizai Shimbun*, November 26, 1984, p. 7, cited in Jonathan Pollack, "China's Changing Perception of East Asia Security and Development," *Orbis*, Winter 1986, p. 787.

35. Xinhua, February 3, 1985, and FBIS, *Daily Report, China*, February 4, 1985.

36. *Asian Wall Street Journal*, December 16, 1985.

37. *Renmin Ribao*, September 19, 1986; *Washington Post*, September 18, 1986.

38. Foreign Minister Wu Xueqian flew to Pyongyang during the hijacking crisis to reaffirm China's disapproval of any two Koreas "machination"; President Li Xiannian visited the DPRK soon after the Seoul Asian Games. See *Renmin Ribao*, May 20, 1983, and *Guangming Ribao*, October 3, 1986.

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yang in dealing with Seoul, PRC leaders will continually consult their North Korean comrades through exchanges of high-level visits.[39]

In the coming decade, Japan will become increasingly important to China. China and Japan share common apprehensions about the growing Soviet military buildup in East Asia and have the same interests in maintaining peace and stability in the Korean peninsula. However, Beijing-Tokyo relations have not been devoid of problems, including trade disputes, the Japanese textbook issue, and the controversy over island territory. The memory of the Japanese invasion of China will continue to make Beijing wary of any signs of a revival of militarism, and Tokyo will prefer that China continue to place a low priority on military modernization. China will continue to pursue a policy of close cooperation with Japan, not only to contain Soviet expansion but also to support China's economic modernization program. Beijing will continue its efforts to solve problems in its relations with Japan by frequent high-level consultations and by mutual compromise. At the same time, the PRC leadership will continue to hint to the Japanese that China does not want to see Japan become a military power and that any resurgence of militarism will evoke a reaction from the Chinese.[40]

Conclusion: Future PRC Policy

In light of China's objectives and possible approaches and the possible trends described above, it would be desirable for Beijing's policy toward Korea and Northeast Asia to be based on the following judgments and to move in the following directions:

China should be concerned but not excessively alarmed by the Soviet buildup in Northeast Asia. It certainly does not serve China's interest. Yet, China should not worry too much about it since the major aim of the Soviet buildup is to counter the American military presence in this region—although it also is a result of Soviet fear of potential U.S.-China-Japan cooperation. China seems to have at least two options in responding to this Soviet buildup. The first is to moderately improve relations with Moscow and distance it from the concept of U.S.-Japan-PRC military cooperation. This might help reduce tension in this region, although it may also entail dangers that are inherent in appeasement. Another response would be to increase cooperative ties with the U.S. and Japan. This would

39. Li Xiannian said to Kim during his recent visit, "We have a good tradition that leaders of both countries love to visit each other frequently like very close relatives. Mao and Zhou had done this, and we will continue to do this." *Renmin Ribao*, October 6, 1986.

40. See Wang Zhaoguo's speech in report of the Conference of Sino-Japanese Friendship for the 21st Century, *Renmin Ribao*, September 23, 1986, p. 6.

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make efforts to counter Soviet expansion more effective and might even impel the Soviets to reevaluate their East Asian policy. Some observers interpret Gorbachev's recent overture to China as the result of the fear of this possibility.[41] Although currently remaining closer to the United States than to the Soviet Union, China seems now to hesitate in making a basic decision and is more or less in the middle between the United States and the USSR.

The "three obstacles" in Sino-Soviet relations should be regarded as a touchstone indicating the Kremlin's real intentions toward Beijing. If the Soviets change their anti-China policy by removing the three obstacles, China could cautiously choose the option of distancing itself from Washington and seeking an equidistant position between the superpowers. However, if these conditions were to be only partially met, the Soviet Union would still constitute the primary threat to China's security, and China should still maintain its close cooperative relationship with the United States. Given the basic, long-term competition between the U.S. and the USSR and the pressing internal economic problems perceived in Beijing, Moscow has incentives to seek relief in its relations with Beijing or at least to partially prevent China from forming closer ties with Washington. Therefore, China should try to direct the current situation in ways that are less potentially explosive and more mutually beneficial. China will see its interests best served by an easing of tension with Moscow, step by step, and at the same time maintaining good relations with Washington. This would further improve China's already favorable position in the U.S.-Soviet-PRC triangle, and would be consistent with the thrust of China's policy interests in the Korean peninsula.

Sino-American relations will continue to be influenced by the Soviet factor. The attempt to deal with the expansion of Soviet military power in the region is likely to preoccupy American leaders for some years to come. Because of the perceived cost to the United States of dealing with the Soviets on its own, Washington is likely to solicit increased support from its allies. Thus, China's value receives a special twist: if the PRC could be counted on to stand up to the Soviet challenge, it would spare America from having to bear the brunt of the fighting in the event of any military conflict. In this context, the United States can be expected to compromise its interests on issues of lesser importance in order to maintain and develop its relations with Beijing so as to strengthen its efforts to contain Soviet expansion. China should be careful, however, not to be accused of playing the Soviets off against the Americans. Beijing should work out a long-term

41. See Gregory Knight, "Soviet China Policy in the Gorbachev Era," *Washington Quarterly*, Spring 1986.

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pattern of dealing with both superpowers and keep it consistent, avoiding any jolts as before.

The improvement of Soviet-North Korean relations demands special attention, but China should recognize the limits in this relationship. In spite of his disillusionment with some of China's current policies, Kim Il Sung is highly unlikely to tilt totally toward Moscow, mainly because of his sense of independence, his view that the *chuch'e* idea represents North Korea's fundamental national interests, and also because of the deep-rooted divergence of interests and distrust between Moscow and Pyongyang. Among fundamental North Korean aspirations, the desire for independence has received the top priority; it is rooted in Korea's historical experience. North Korea thus will resist Soviet efforts at de facto integration. Chinese sensitivity, and Soviet insensitivity, to North Korea's desire for independence has contributed to the character of Pyongyang-Moscow and Pyongyang-Beijing relations.[42]

The Soviets always find the North Koreans intractable, ungrateful, and difficult to manage. Pyongyang has often gone contrary to Soviet wishes and sometimes openly attacked Moscow's policies. But because of the strategic importance of North Korea, Moscow cannot treat Pyongyang harshly. The current North Korean leadership sees the USSR as a big, threatening neighbor that would like to dominate North Korea as it does Mongolia. The North Korean leaders also recognize that they must depend on the Soviets to some extent, economically and militarily, and more importantly as the principal counter to U.S.-backed South Korea. This unavoidable dependence breeds frustration and resentment.[43] Moscow keeps North Korea on a short rein, providing neither the military nor the economic support that it would like to have. Moscow's reliability is also questionable; the historical lesson of the Korean War is still fresh in the minds of the DPRK's leadership: It was the Chinese not the Soviets that came to the defense of the DPRK. These factors resulted in DPRK-Soviet bilateral relations remaining cool, and sometimes strained, for most of the last two decades and they are likely to create obstacles to close relations in the future.

China should be prepared to accept a moderate improvement in Soviet relations with the DPRK, so long as this does not threaten China's fundamental strategic and political interests in North Korea. In fact, such a trend might have three beneficial implications for Beijing. First, it could reduce the Soviet fear of being surrounded by a new containment system and excluded from peninsular affairs and thus compelled to resort to pro-

42. See Gelman and Levin, *The Future of Soviet-North Korean Relations.*

43. See Ralph Clough, "The Soviet Union and the Two Koreas."

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vocative actions via North Korea. As a result of the recent reduction of Sino-Soviet tensions, this concern has subsided considerably. Second, it would encourage Pyongyang to continue its independent policy, which serves Chinese interests better than its dependence on either Moscow or Beijing. As a vital buffer to Soviet expansion, an independent North Korea is clearly of greater utility to Beijing than it is to Moscow. Third, since Moscow is not interested in an open conflict in the peninsula either, it might be helpful if the Soviets do preserve some influence and help to prevent provocative actions from both Korean states.

China should try to avoid serving as a host, mediator, or chairman in any tripartite negotiations. If China can promote the idea of tripartite talks and accomplish some tangible results on the DPRK's behalf, this could help to solidify Chinese relations with North Korea. If, however, China fails to do this, it could reduce China's credibility and utility in the eyes of the North Koreans, who will see clearly the limits of China's diplomatic abilities as well as Pyongyang of the Sino-American detente, and might then tilt toward the Soviets for diplomatic support.

Although until very recently China has lagged behind the Soviet Union in semi-official dealings with South Korea, it is clear that Pyongyang is extremely sensitive to Chinese openings toward South Korea. This sensitivity in Pyongyang reveals the importance of China in the DPRK's policy calculations, which China should appreciate and value. China's economic contacts with Seoul should not be expanded to the extent that PRC-DPRK relations might be compromised. North Korea should always be a higher priority. China should not change its opposition to all "two Koreas" formulas—such as "cross-recognition" and the "simultaneous admission" to the United Nations. If Pyongyang modifies its position on these issues, so can China. China should be careful about dealing officially with Seoul. Any formal official contact might be regarded as an indication of China's willingness to accept the "two Koreas" idea, which in turn could be viewed in some countries as strengthening the case for "two Chinas". Seoul has openly indicated that if the PRC deals with South Korea diplomatically, it would sever its relations with Taipei. Although this would further the PRC's efforts to isolate Taiwan in the world community, the cost would surpass the benefits.

Finally, China should concentrate its efforts on domestic economic development to try to ensure that its modernization program succeeds. The PRC's current GNP is estimated to be US$567 billion, about 40% of that of the Soviet Union. If China keeps its annual growth rate at about 7%, as is projected, its GNP may reach 60% of that of the USSR in 1990 and

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about 86% by the year 2000.[44] Success in the PRC's modernization drive throughout the 1990s would not only increase its economic leverage on North Korea relative to that of the Soviet Union, but would also have significant effects on North Korea's international economic orientation and its foreign policy. Economic considerations are expected to loom larger than ever before in China's policy toward the Korean peninsula.

44. See Dwight Perkins, "The Economic Background and Implications for China," in Herbert Ellison, ed., *The Sino-Soviet Conflict: A Global Perspective* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1982), pp. 91–111; also *Beijing Review*, February 28, 1983.

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